



Bridge the Gap: City Heights Youth Opportunity Initiative

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Introduction & Background

City Heights and La Jolla are both part of San Diego Unified School District (SDUSD) and receive the same base funding per student under California's Local Control Funding Formula. Yet City Heights students have far fewer AP courses, clubs, and after-school programs than La Jolla students. City Heights is home to 17 public schools serving mostly low-income, immigrant, and refugee families — a population where equal opportunity is a matter of daily impact, not abstract policy.

SDG 4

Quality Education

SDG 10

Reduced Inequalities

Research Questions

- How large is the gap in PTA/foundation fundraising between City Heights and La Jolla schools?
- How does that funding gap relate to differences in AP course access, robotics teams, and academic competitions?
- What do City Heights families themselves report about awareness of and participation in these opportunities?

Conclusion

Same public funding, very different opportunities. The City Heights/La Jolla gap comes from community fundraising capacity, not unequal state funding — and it holds up across the whole district, not just these two neighborhoods. That means it is solvable through targeted support, not a funding-formula fight.

Study Limitations

- One-semester student project — limited time and data-collection resources.
- Survey (n=18) was recruited through community channels, not a district-wide random sample.
- “No confirmed revenue” reflects missing public records, not a verified zero — the true gap is likely at least this large, not smaller.
- Findings are observational (public records + self-report survey), not a controlled causal study.

Vulnerable Population Snapshot

~65,000

residents in City Heights, one of San Diego's most densely populated, diverse neighborhoods

1 in 3

City Heights residents were born outside the United States

\$30,000

approximate median household income in City Heights per year

45+

countries of origin represented among City Heights families

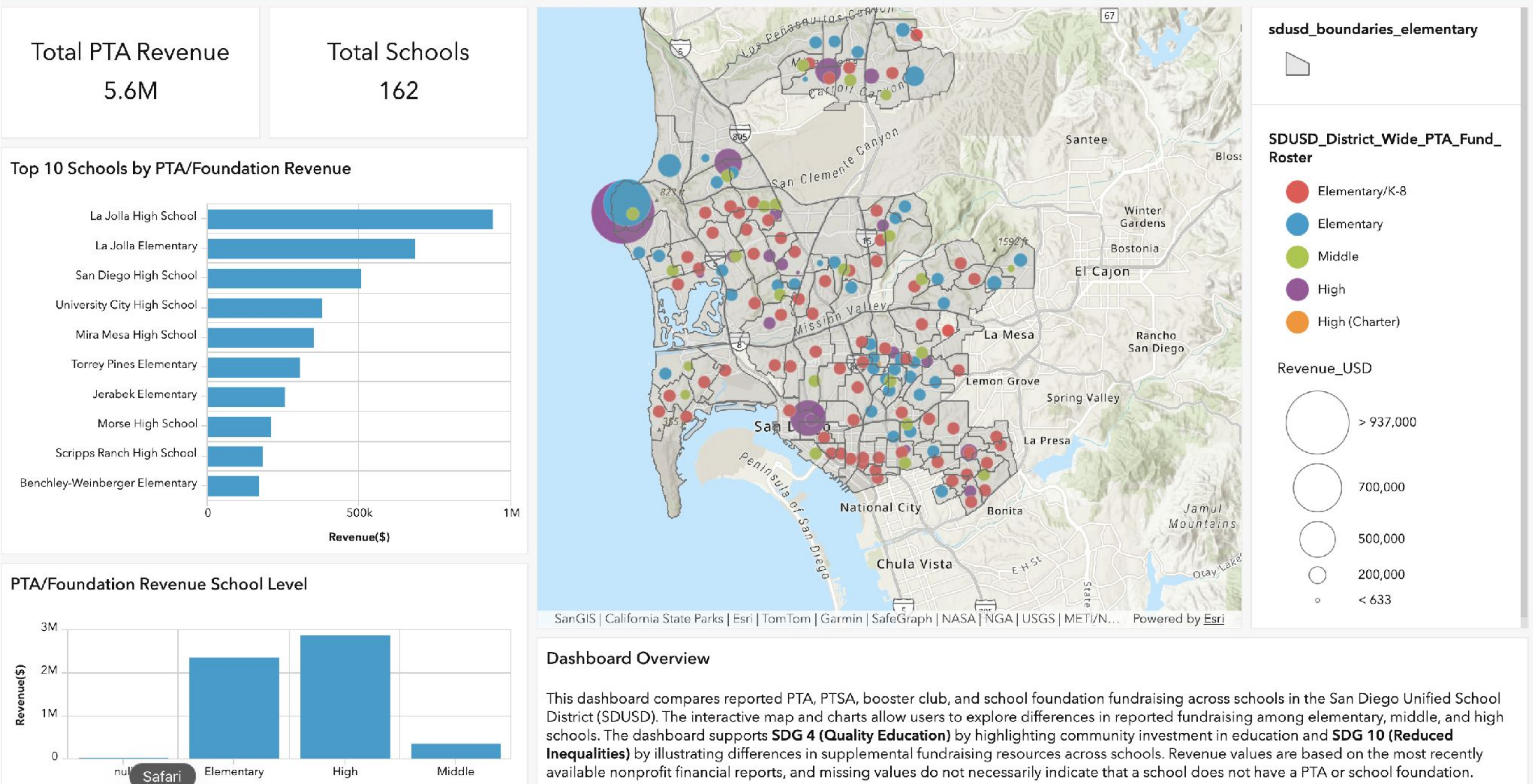
Literature Review

- Nationally, PTA/foundation fundraising varies enormously by school wealth, widening resource gaps public funding formulas were meant to equalize (Brown, Sargrad & Benner, 2017; Mackevicius, 2022).
- California AP access has long been unequal by school income level (Zarate & Pachon, 2006).
- Ladson-Billings (2006) reframes the achievement gap as an education debt owed to under-resourced communities.
- Immigrant and low-income families' lower involvement in school fundraising reflects real barriers, not lack of interest (Park & McHugh, 2014).

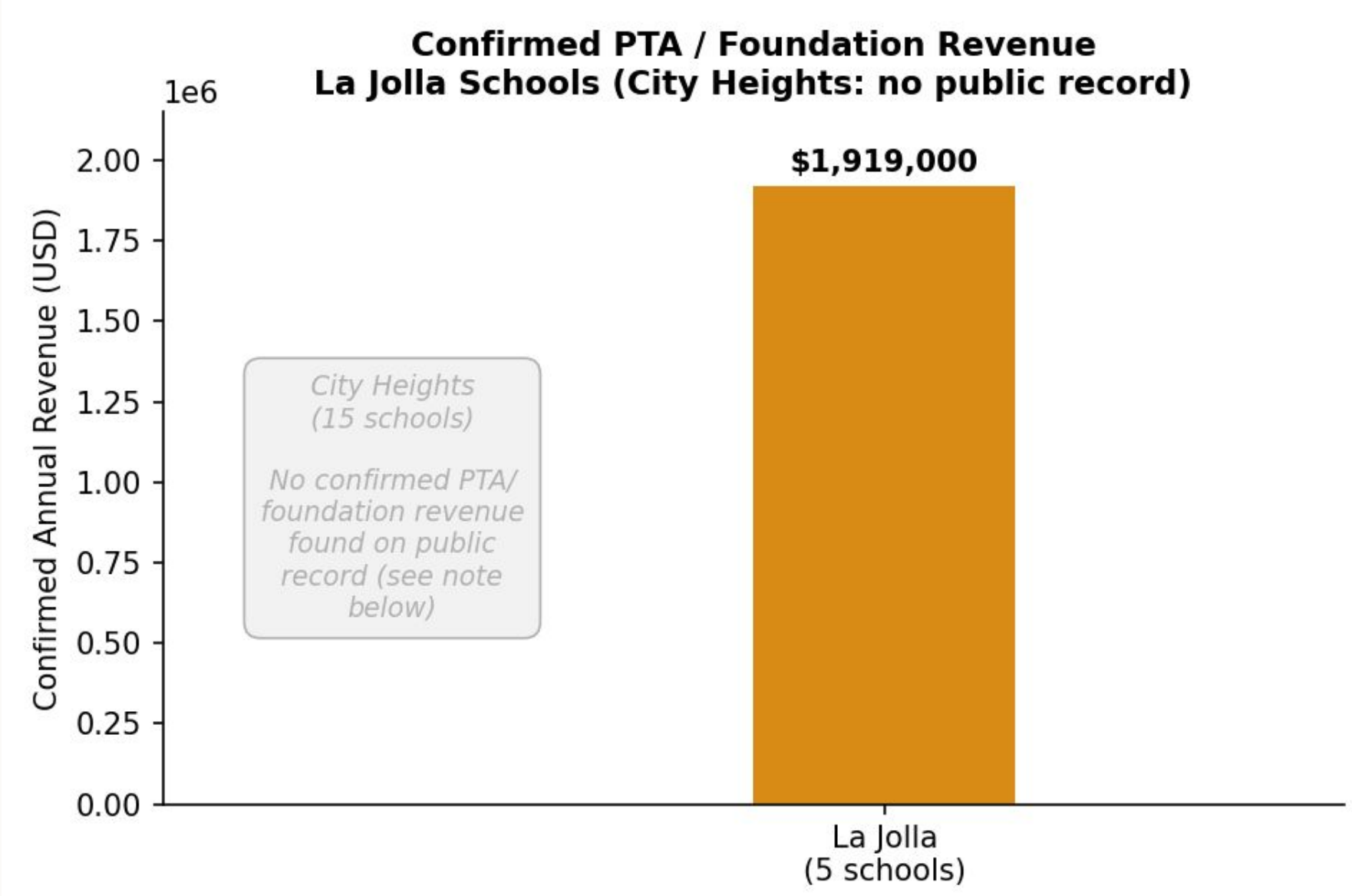
Methods

- Public records: IRS Form 990/990-EZ filings (via ProPublica), the College Board AP Course Ledger, and School Accountability Report Cards.
- District-wide ArcGIS Online dashboard mapping PTA/foundation revenue at all 162 SDUSD schools.
- Bilingual (English/Spanish) survey of 18 City Heights families on income, PTA participation, and awareness of school programs.

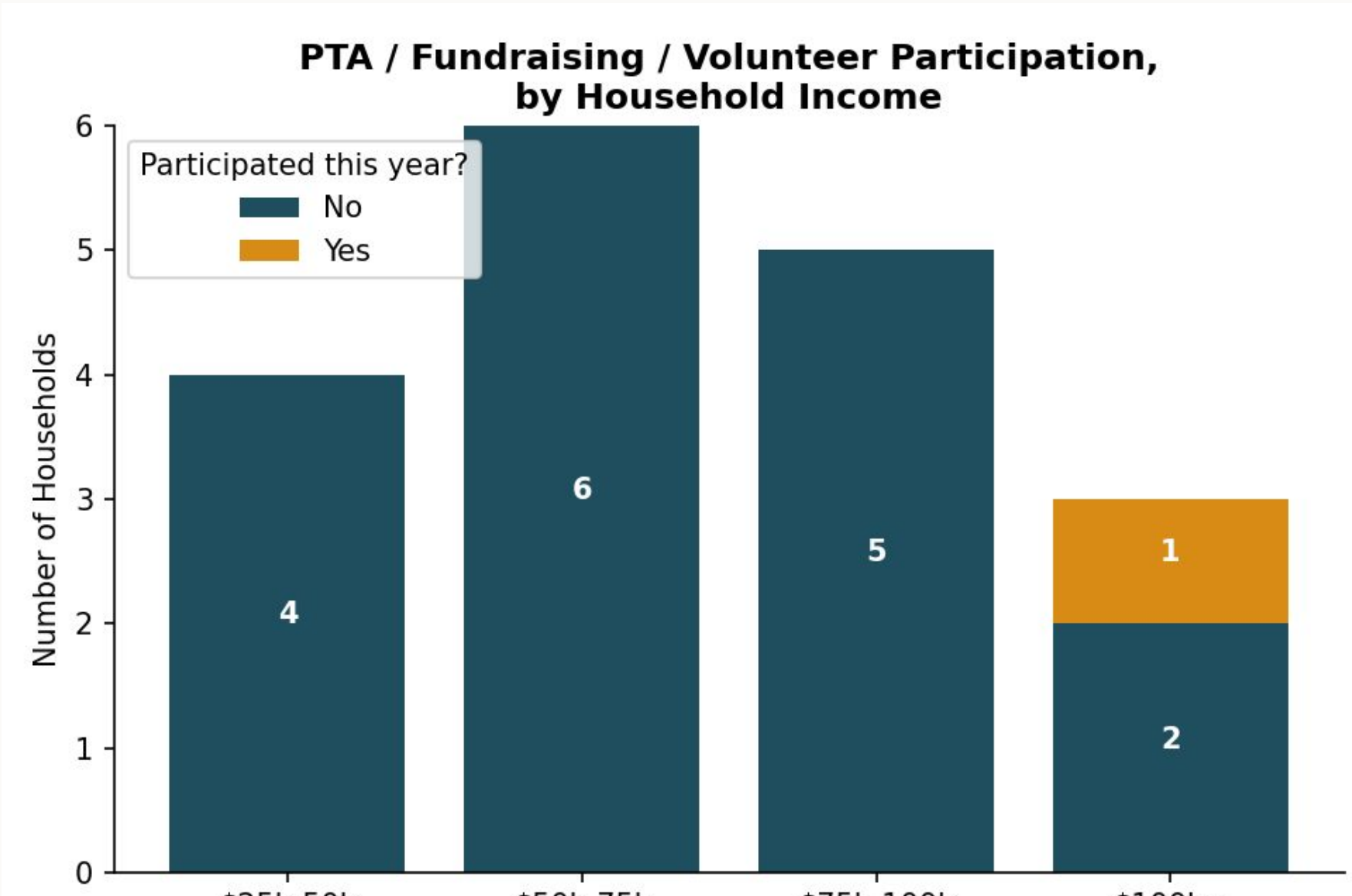
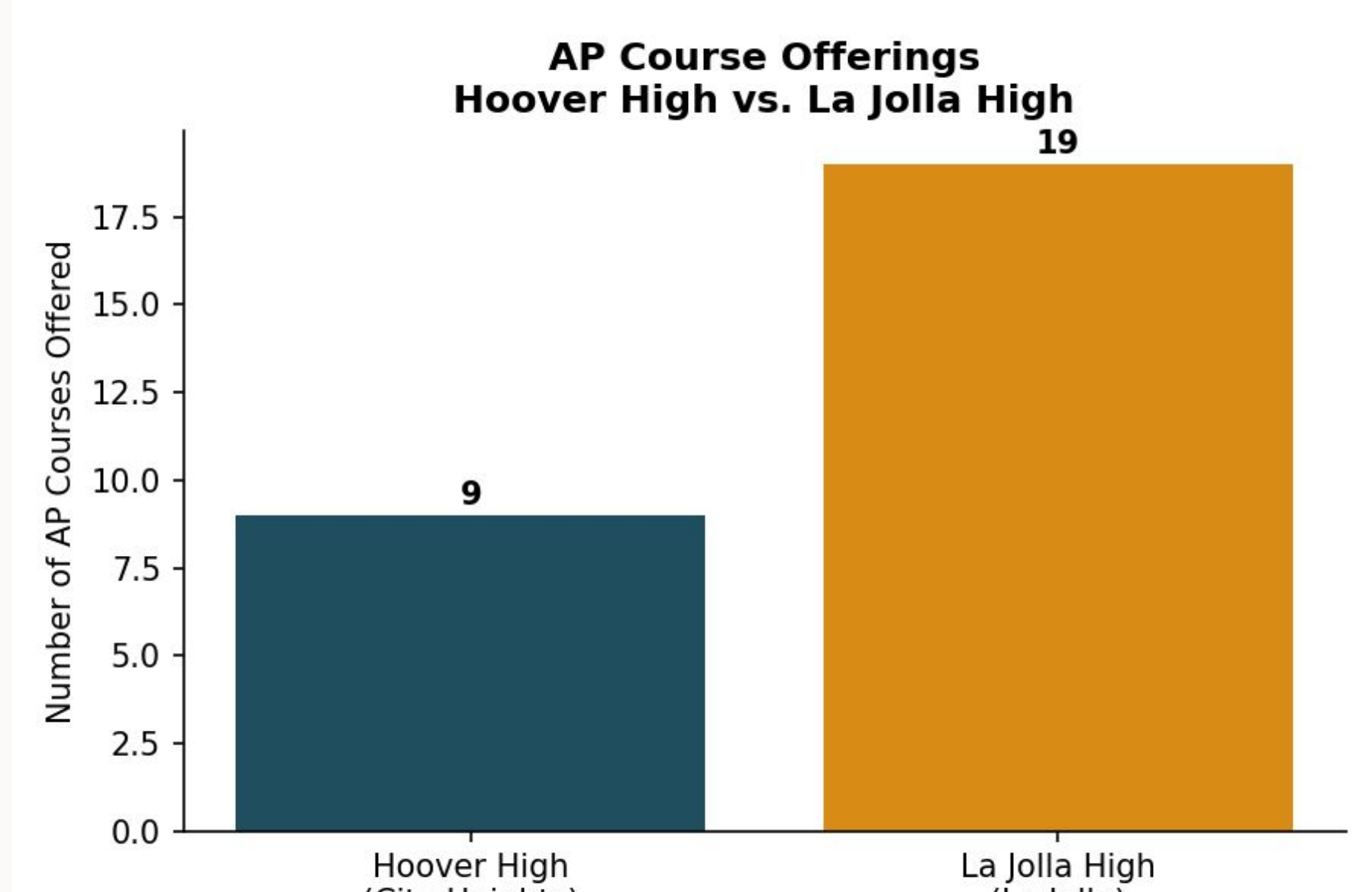
Maps & Visualizations



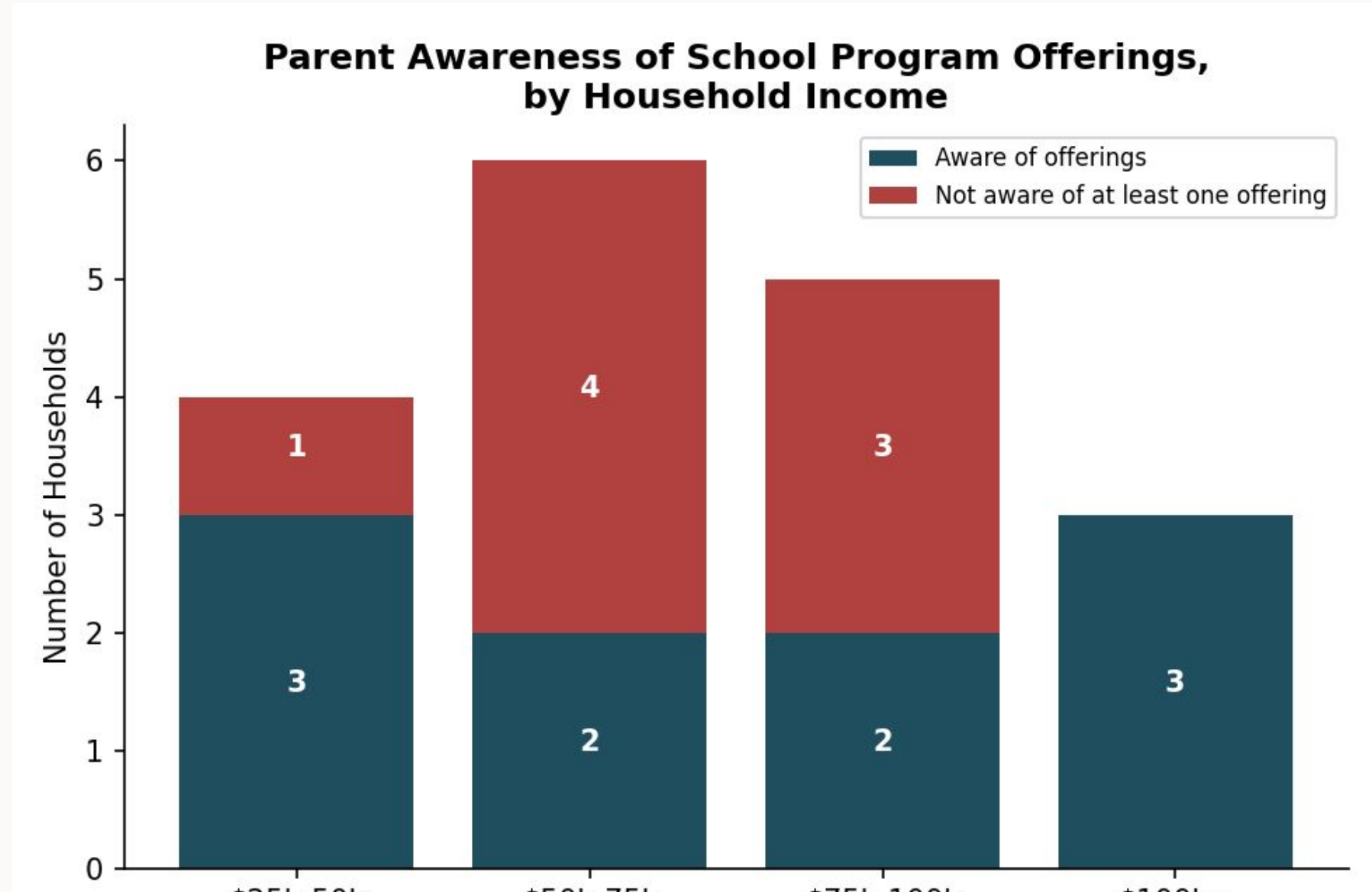
SDUSD PTA & School Equity Dashboard (ArcGIS Online) — all 162 district schools. Circle size shows confirmed PTA/foundation revenue; color shows school level. Large circles cluster almost entirely along the coast.



Left: confirmed PTA/foundation revenue, La Jolla schools vs. no public record for City Heights. Right: AP course offerings, Hoover High (City Heights) vs. La Jolla High.



Survey results from 18 City Heights households: PTA/fundraising participation (left) and awareness of school program offerings (right), broken out by household income range.



Key Findings

\$1.9M vs \$0

Confirmed La Jolla PTA/foundation revenue vs. \$0 confirmed in City Heights (core comparison schools)

9 vs 19

AP courses offered: Hoover High (City Heights) vs. La Jolla High

\$5.6M / 18%

Confirmed PTA/foundation revenue across all 162 SDUSD schools — only 18% of schools have any confirmed figure

5.6%

Of surveyed City Heights families took part in PTA/fundraising activity this year

44%

Of surveyed families didn't know whether their child's school offers at least one AP/Honors or club/sports program

Robotics is the exception that proves the rule: Wilson Middle (City Heights) runs a more decorated program than La Jolla's lapsed Muirlands team — showing the gap is about funding reliability, not student ability.

Call to Action

- SDUSD Board & LCAP: use this data as public comment evidence for equity-targeted funding.
- Companies & foundations: sponsor City Heights PTAs/programs through CSR and education-equity grants.
- Families & PTA leaders: use the dashboard to compare your school and start the conversation locally.

References & Acknowledgments

Brown, Sargrad & Benner (2017), Center for American Progress • Mackevicius (2022), Urban Institute • Zarate & Pachon (2006), Tomás Rivera Policy Institute • Ladson-Billings (2006), Educational Researcher • Park & McHugh (2014), Migration Policy Institute. Full references in final report.

With thanks to Dr. Gabriela Fernandez and the 18 City Heights families who completed the survey.

Scan to explore the project online:



Project Website



Live Dashboard

Get in Touch

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“Same district. Same funding. Different opportunities.”

That's the gap this project maps — and the one we're asking City Heights to help close.